

EUROPE

A GREAT CURVE OF mountain ranges that includes the Pyrenees and the Alps roughly divides the cooler north of Europe from the warmer south. In the far north, treeless tundra merges into cool coniferous forests that extend across Scandinavia and into Russia. South of this lies the fertile North European Plain, which supports most of the continent's agriculture and mixed woodland. By contrast, the Mediterranean region to the south is hot and almost desertlike in places. Volcanic activity is confined to Iceland and southern Italy, where Mount Etna is constantly active. The Ural and Caucasus mountains form Europe's eastern borders.



Bird's Eye primrose

THE ALPS

The mountains that form the Alps run from southeastern France, through Switzerland and Italy, into Austria. In the last 2 million years, ice has molded the scenery, carving pyramid-shaped peaks, like the Matterhorn (above), knife-edged ridges, dramatic waterfalls, and armchair-shaped basins filled with lakes. Alpine plants, such as the Bird's Eye primrose, have adapted to growing at high altitudes.

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